

THE UPCOMING EDITION OF THE HIL FEATURES A WOMEN'S TOURNAMENT FOR THE FIRST TIME IN ITS HISTORY

Soorma HC

Men: The JSW-owned Soormas were determined to land the country's biggest name at the moment, Harmanpreet Singh, and succeeded by not scrimping on the purse, even willing to break the bank for the Indian captain.

They also have a shrewd tactician in former Indian midfielder Arjun Halappa as technical director, and a brilliant reader of the game in Sardar Singh as the mentor. It is a combination that worked wonders on the field before, and the team will hope it does so again off it.

However, Harmanpreet is not

the only weapon; Australian Jeremy Hayward is equally potent with drag-flicks and boasts an equally intimidating conversion record.

Their midfield is a mixed bag, though, with Belgian Victor Wegnez key to their chances, and an opportunity for former junior India captain Harjeet Singh to return to national prominence after falling off the radar in recent years.

The forwards lack firepower, so the team will be counting on Harmanpreet and Hayward to do the bulk of its scoring. Meanwhile, Vincent Vanasch, the only man to win the FIH Goalkeeper of the Year award thrice, will be a perfect mentor for Mohit H. S. in goal.

Women: This side, on paper, has no apparent weakness, apart from high expectations. Current national captain Salima Tete will be central to its attacking efforts, while veteran Savita Punia will be crucial in goal. The midfield pairing of Nike Lorenz and Maria Verschoor will be key to managing the team and with Rani Rampal on the coaching staff, also doubling up as the mentor, it will be an interesting reunion that can end up being either spectacularly

successful or disastrous.

Team Gonasika

Men: Every team has its big/small players and good/bad players, but there is only one Tom Boon. He has led the scoring charts an incredible 12 times in competitions involving three or more teams and has 291 goals in 354 international matches, scoring them in every way possible — be it drag-flicks, field goals, simple tap-ins or from acute angles.

Getting him for Rs. 26 lakhs was a steal for Team Gonasika — especially considering he was the costliest player in HIL 1.0 back in 2014, fetching 103,000 USD, equivalent to over Rs. 80 lakhs today. The side will be hoping the Belgian legend leads it to the knockouts.

Star Dutch forward Jeroen Hertzberger will join him upfront, but while the rest of the team is competent, it doesn't excite. There is a strong Indian core, including Mandeep Singh, Manpreet Singh, Amir Ali, Suraj Karkera, and Vishnukant Singh, as well as returning veterans Nikkin Thimmaiah, S. K. Uthappa, and S. V. Sunil.

The Boon edge: Tom Boon has been the leading scorer an incredible 12 times in competitions featuring three or more teams through his career.

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